POLITICS · POWER · ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE

Is there light at the end of the tunnel?

The antinomies of power, the limits of freedom, and the possibility of a civilization that can correct itself

FIRST VERSION
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A Note on This First Version

This book begins with an unease: systems that promise to free us tend to reconstruct, in another form, the dependencies they were invented to oppose. Equality can conceal a caste. Economic freedom can buy political power. Democracy can elect its enemies. Decentralization can produce small tyrannies. Abundance can eliminate poverty without eliminating humiliation.

The starting point includes the experience of communism described by the book's initiator. That experience is treated as testimony and a source of questions, not artificially turned into a representative sample. The text invents no autobiographical scenes, characters, or memories. The analysis examines mechanisms; it does not retroactively issue certificates of virtue to entire classes.

The arguments use four registers. Empirical findings are attributed to the cited studies. Concepts and theorems are presented along with their limitations. The book's own causal reconstructions are framed as possible mechanisms, not as laws already demonstrated. Institutional proposals and scenarios concerning artificial intelligence are working hypotheses, not guaranteed predictions. An explanation can be coherent and still false: moving from possibility to truth requires evidence.

Numbered references point to the bibliography at the end. It combines empirical research, theoretical works, and primary political texts; the type of source is specified where confusion would matter. The bibliography is selective, not the result of an exhaustive systematic review. This first version was developed with AI assistance from

the questions and positions supplied by the initiator. Online references were checked for this version on September 13, 2026; independent editorial verification of their interpretations is also recommended before publication.

Introduction — When the Exit Resembles the Entrance

A society can escape an aristocracy only to find that the administrators of liberation have become the new aristocracy. It can privatize the economy to limit the state, only to find that the state has been bought. It can expand political rights and produce a majority that wants to restrict them. It can automate work and turn freedom from necessity into dependence on the owners of automation. None of these developments is inevitable. All are plausible enough to make faith in a saving formula ridiculous.

This book does not begin with the notion that people are too evil for freedom. Nor does it begin with the opposite notion that good institutions will bring forth a hidden goodness distributed evenly among everyone. People differ in competence, self-control, curiosity, generosity, and their ability to bear frustration. The same person can behave admirably in one context and abusively in another. The problem of government cannot be solved through a convenient anthropology in which evil always belongs to the other side.

The initial question appears ideological: capitalism or socialism, state or market, center or community? On closer inspection, it is architectural. Who can compel whom? Who decides what counts as evidence? Who can challenge a decision without losing their livelihood? Who

bears the cost of an error, and who receives its benefit? Who can replace those who make mistakes? These questions do not disappear when we change the owner's name.

There is an intellectual temptation to declare all systems equivalent. That is false profundity. A press dependent on advertising is not the same as one where criticizing the ruler leads to prison. A market with limited mobility is not the same as a prohibition on leaving. A partially captured democracy is not the same as a party that simultaneously controls careers, the police, and official truth. Differences in degree can become differences in kind when they affect the possibility of correction.

There is also a symmetrical temptation: to use comparative superiority as a certificate of innocence. The fact that one order is preferable to another does not make it just, stable, or immune to degradation. A system can be the best available and still contain mechanisms that gradually destroy its advantages. Liberal democracy deserves to be defended precisely without hiding this vulnerability.

By “light,” we will not mean the end of conflict, difference, or ambition. A civilization of free beings cannot promise that no one will ever want something incompatible with what another person wants. We will seek a more modest possibility, and for that very reason a more serious one: institutions in which domination encounters obstacles, errors produce information, and changing the leadership does not require demolishing society.

At the end of the inquiry stands no new “ism” that declares its opponents resolved. Instead, there is a proposal for constitutional cosmolocalism: knowledge circulating globally, economic capabilities distributed widely, rights that do not depend on the goodwill of the local community, and common coordination against dangers that do not respect community borders. The proposal will be attacked at its own weak points. If it cannot withstand that treatment, it does not deserve to be a source of hope.

PART I — POWER CHANGES ITS COSTUME

CHAPTER 1

The Curse of Antinomies

To live together, we must limit power. To limit power, we must organize another power.

A Contradiction Is Not Always an Antinomy

Kant did not call every dispute in which both sides have arguments an antinomy. In the Critique of Pure Reason, antinomies arise when reason applies certain demands beyond the domain in which it can justify them, arriving at seemingly demonstrable theses and antitheses. Here, transferring the term to politics is a methodological analogy, not a claim to the authority of a Kantian proof. [1]

Most of the political contradictions discussed in this book are not logical contradictions. We are not claiming at once that a proposition is true and false in the same sense. Rather, we encounter conflicting aims, mechanisms that turn against their own purpose, and institutions that need conditions they cannot produce by themselves. Security may require discretion; discretion may protect abuse. Participation may improve legitimacy; unlimited participation in every decision may make action impossible.

The distinction matters. A logical contradiction calls for revising the premises. A trade-off between aims calls for a justified choice. A self-destructive mechanism calls for identifying the conditions that activate it. Calling every difficulty an “eternal paradox” is an elegant way of giving up on the work before it begins.

We will call a situation a political antinomy when two justifiable requirements, pursued without limits or complementary institutions, come to undermine one another. This is a working definition. It does not prove that every balance is impossible. On the contrary, it requires us to ask whether the opposition is fundamental or arises from an impoverished description of the alternatives.

Privilege Does Not Live Only in Money

Imagine two people with almost equal incomes. One can decide whether to employ the other, block their movements, and influence the investigation of a complaint against themselves. The other can do nothing comparable. To say they are nearly equal because their salaries are close is an error in measuring power, not merely a moral shortcoming.

Now change the institutions. The first person no longer controls the police but owns the infrastructure through which the second finds clients, preserves a professional reputation, and receives income. The first person can change the rules unilaterally. The dependency is not the same, and legal recourse may make the decisive difference. Still, a structural problem reappears: access to social life is mediated by an authority that the dependent person can challenge only at great cost.

I propose here the hypothesis of privilege conversion. Economic, administrative, informational, coercive, and symbolic advantages can be converted into one another. When a reform blocks only one form, powerful actors can move toward those that remain available. Nationalizing wealth can increase the value of office. Liberalization can increase the value of capital capable of influencing the rules. Transparency can increase the value of the ability to drown inconvenient information in a larger volume of convenient information.

This is neither a proven universal law nor a claim that every reform is useless. It is a mechanism to investigate. Cases in which reform reduces one concentration without relevant power reconstituting itself along other dimensions would weaken it. Such cases are exactly what we should seek. A theory that explains every outcome by invoking invisible elites no longer explains anything verifiable.

A Solution Should Be Judged by the Adversary It Can Withstand

Many doctrines work if the adversary is described conveniently. The free market works wonderfully if monopolies do not arise, contracts are genuinely voluntary, and costs are not imposed on others. Planning works wonderfully if administrators know people's needs, tell the truth, and can be replaced without conflict. Direct democracy works wonderfully if citizens have time, information, and the willingness to lose gracefully.

No real order can demand that all these conditions be met forever. Yet it makes no sense to demand that it withstand every imaginable adversary with unlimited resources. Such a test would declare every institution impossible. The reasonable test is more precise: what realistic combinations of corruption, opportunism, incompetence, polarization, and external shock can it absorb without losing its mechanisms of correction?

Michels formulated the tendency of mass organizations toward oligarchy. This calls for vigilance regarding control of the agenda, administrative expertise, and continuity of leadership. Yet it should not be elevated to an inescapable fate. Lipset, Trow, and Coleman's study of union democracy shows precisely the importance of organizational conditions that can sustain internal competition. [4, 5]

The book's first result, then, is negative only in appearance: there is no magical substitute for organizing counterpower. The positive result is that the form of counterpower can be designed, compared, and improved. The curse begins when we treat one instrument as a total solution. It weakens when we ask where that instrument works, where it fails, and who can correct its failure.

CHAPTER 2

Equality That Invented Its Own Nobles

Abolishing privileged property can destroy an aristocracy. It can also concentrate ownership, promotion, and punishment in the same hands.

A Caste Without Titles

The experience of communism recounted at the starting point of this book concerns more than material shortages. It concerns the disparity between proclaimed equality and the discretionary freedom of those in the political and repressive apparatus. An ordinary person might have an income not very far from an important official's formal income and still inhabit a completely different world: different risks, different access, different protection before the rules.

The concept of the “new class,” formulated by Milovan Djilas, captures the transformation of political control into a collective privilege of the ruling apparatus. His book is a political analysis arising from inside the system, not an experimental measurement of all communist societies. Kornai offers a more systematic reconstruction of the connection between political monopoly and the features of the classical socialist economy. [2, 3]

The analogy with nobility is useful if it does not conceal the differences. Bureaucratic privilege was not legally identical to hereditary feudal property. Leaders could be purged; descendants did not always hold a formally transmitted title. Yet offices, relationships, access to institutions, and informal protection could reproduce advantages. In a functional sense, an unchallengeable hierarchy could be reestablished in the language of abolishing hierarchies.

The mechanism can be described without assuming that every member of the apparatus was sadistic or corrupt. If an organization controls the main career paths and can punish challenges, people learn that proximity to it is a resource. Even administrators who initially mean well are pushed to select predictable and loyal people. Competence remains necessary for producing results, but it becomes dangerous when coupled with independence.

When the Specialist Knows but Cannot Decide

A technological society needs people who understand material strength, calculation errors, the limits of a technology, and the costs of an investment. Ideology cannot negotiate with physics indefinitely. The problem arises when specialists can describe the limits but cannot compel decision-makers to heed them, while honest reporting threatens their careers.

Here domination meets the degradation of information. The expert can become a supplier of justifications for a decision already made. The administrator asks for feasibility; the expert learns to produce feasibility on paper. The next level reports success because the level below it did so. A perfectly coordinated conspiracy is unnecessary. A ladder of incentives is enough when inconvenient truth has an immediate cost, while collective error imposes a later cost distributed across the population.

This description is a reconstruction of a mechanism, not a diagnosis of every laboratory or enterprise. There have been remarkable professionals, genuine intellectual communities, and activities in which technical standards withstood pressure. The testimony that mathematics and technical sciences could offer relative refuges is intelligible: some errors are harder to hide when an answer can be independently verified. But science is not automatically a territory beyond power either.

The deepest moral degradation is not simply that lies exist. It is the learning of a double language: everyone knows what must be said publicly and what can be admitted in a small circle. When the official rule no longer describes actual practice, success may depend more on navigating relationships than on completing the task. Here declarative egalitarianism can become a school of cynicism.

What This Failure Does Not Prove

The conclusion cannot be that every reduction in inequality reproduces communism. That would confuse the distribution of outcomes with the structure of power. Progressive taxation under a system with changes of government, an independent judiciary, and plural ownership is not equivalent to a party monopoly over the economy. Neither public services nor cooperatives logically imply a political police.

Likewise, the claim that “socialism inevitably produces poverty” is too broad. One must specify the form of ownership, coordination mechanism, freedoms, starting point, and period being compared. Analysis of the classical socialist economy does not exhaust every form of democratic socialism, market socialism, or common ownership. It is more exacting and more accurate to identify the dangerous combination: political concentration, an economy dependent on administrative decisions, and weakened independent feedback.

An honest accounting can acknowledge expanded social access or experiences of cooperation where documented, without turning benefits into an alibi for repression. In this book, the experience of cooperation recalled by its initiator is not denied, but neither is it converted into proof of the system's general superiority. Cooperation can be genuine solidarity; it can also be a defensive adaptation to scarcity. Both can coexist.

The lesson is not that equality should be abandoned. It is that equality must extend beyond income: equality before procedures, the right to challenge decisions, protection against retaliation, and genuine access to alternatives. A society that equalizes consumption but arbitrarily distributes the right to govern others has not solved the problem of privilege. It has changed the currency in which privilege is paid.

CHAPTER 3

Competence, Motivation, and the Right to Make Mistakes

A society must reward contribution. If it reduces a person's worth to measured contribution, it creates dependency, contempt, and manipulation of the measurement.

How Much Inequality Does Excellence Require?

It is plausible that severely reducing differences in rewards can weaken some forms of effort and risk-taking. It does not follow that every existing difference is necessary. Between the statement “incentives matter” and the statement “all fortunes reflect deserved contributions” lies a distance that ideology crosses without proof.

A specialist's reward may take the form of money, autonomy, access to tools, reputation, and the opportunity to work with competent people. One regime can pay relatively well and destroy motivation through arbitrary subordination. Another can pay modestly and sustain exceptional work through professional freedom. Self-determination theory emphasizes autonomy, competence, and relatedness; it neither reduces motivation to price nor says that money is irrelevant. [39]

The serious problem is to establish a difference sufficient to attract and sustain contribution without turning it into an unlimited right to command. A valuable researcher has reason to receive resources and recognition. That does not mean they should unilaterally set housing policy or their neighbors' rights. An entrepreneur may organize a company admirably and be a poor judge of the public interest.

Here we must separate three things often conflated: competence in a domain, power over a task, and civic status. The first must be demonstrated. The second must be bounded. The third is not a prize awarded for performance. Civic equality does not require us to pretend that everyone can design a reactor. It requires that the reactor's designer does not thereby gain the right to make us subjects.

The Plan Does Not Know Everything; the Market Does Not Value Everything

Hayek stressed the dispersed character of economic knowledge: much relevant information exists locally, in forms that are hard to centralize. This argument explains an important limit of planning and an advantage of mechanisms that permit decentralized adjustment. It does not prove that every price is morally right or every market competitive. [6]

A price expresses a relationship between effective demand and supply within a set of rules. A need unsupported by money may remain poorly represented. Caring for a vulnerable person can be vital yet poorly paid. A profitable activity can shift costs onto people who are not parties to the contract. These are reasons not to equate social value with income, not reasons to discard the information that prices supply.

Conversely, administrators can calculate costs and consult specialists without turning the exercise into complete knowledge of preferences and the future. A well-designed public budget is not an omniscient collective mind. An economic decision remains a hypothesis about behavior, constraints, and responses, not merely an accounting operation.

A realistic order needs several mechanisms of discovery: competitive markets where their conditions are plausible, public funding for goods difficult to supply otherwise, professional autonomy, and associations for interests that are poorly represented. The mixture is not a recipe in itself. Each mechanism must be judged by its results and by the possibility of correcting its administrators.

Security That Suffocates and Insecurity That Disciplines Too Much

Kornai analyzed the problem of the soft budget constraint: repeated expectations of rescue can change organizational behavior and reduce economic discipline. At the same time, discussion of tightening this constraint during transition shows that speed and social consequences matter. A harsh rule can impose costs that a society cannot bear politically or morally. [7]

This mechanism does not imply that every person should be kept on the brink of disaster to be productive. The bankruptcy of a firm and a person's loss of access to medical care are not the same instrument. A society can allow projects to fail without permanently destroying the people involved. Indeed, basic protection can make risk-taking more accessible to those without family wealth.

This is one of the central antinomies of merit. Without consequences for poor decisions, competence may cease to matter. With disproportionate consequences, only those already protected can afford to experiment. An order that claims to select talent may in fact select the tolerance for risk financed by family resources.

The solution is not to abolish differences but to limit the conversion of failure into total exclusion. Expertise must be rewarded, but also tested. Performance must be assessed relative to resources and conditions, not only the final result. Success can justify operational autonomy, not immunity. And failure to excel must not be turned into a fault for which a person loses the right to a decent life.

CHAPTER 4

Capitalism: The Ladder and the Owners of the Ladder

The possibility of succeeding is a real freedom. It does not prove that the probability of succeeding is fairly distributed.

Hope Is Not an Illusion, but Neither Is It a Statistic

A young person who can change jobs, start a business, publish without party approval, and emigrate has real possibilities. Describing all these freedoms as mere scenery for exploitation misses essential differences. For someone who has experienced administrative control over a career, they can represent a profound change in one's relationship with the future.

But a legal possibility does not establish a social probability. Two people may have the right to start the same business yet very different capacities to withstand a year without income. Family, housing, health, access to relationships, and the ability to recover from failure alter the competition. We do not need to deny effort to notice unequal starting points.

Chetty and colleagues' study of absolute mobility in the United States estimates a sharp decline in the share of children who come to earn more than their parents: from roughly nine out of ten in the cohort born in 1940 to roughly half in the 1980 cohort, according to the definitions and adjustments used. This concerns absolute income mobility, not any individual's probability of rising in the social ranking, nor every capitalist economy. [12]

The distinction between absolute and relative mobility matters. In an economy growing enough, almost everyone can live materially better than their parents without much change in the ranking of families. Conversely, a society can frequently replace the occupants of its top positions while leaving much of the population in precarious circumstances. A legitimate order must examine both dimensions: how much life improves and how much one's position depends on social origin.

When Reward Buys the Rules

Capitalism can reward innovation. It can also reward control of a scarce resource, restrictions on competition, administrative protection, or the shifting of risk onto others. Profit does not bear a moral label identifying the mechanism that produced it. Thus, defending the market also requires defending access to it against incumbents.

Capture begins when success in a game is used to rewrite its rules in favor of the winner. Not all representation of interests is corruption. Lawmakers need information from those affected. The problem is the disparity: access, legal expertise, and sustained influence can be distributed very unequally, while the dispersed interests of many people are harder to organize than the concentrated benefit of a few. Olson offers a classic framework for understanding this asymmetry in collective action. [10]

Gilens and Page studied 1,779 public-policy proposals in the United States from 1981 to 2002. In their models, the preferences of economic elites and certain organized groups appear to have substantial independent influence, while the estimated independent influence of the average citizen is much smaller. The research is observational, concerns a bounded historical context, and faces identification difficulties when the groups' preferences coincide. It does not prove that citizens do not matter at all or that every decision is bought. [11]

The relevant conclusion is more precise: equality at the ballot box does not guarantee equality of influence between elections. A democracy can remain competitive while simultaneously producing policies disproportionately responsive to actors with the resources to remain constantly present.

Meritocratic Hypocrisy and the Reaction to It

Meritocracy becomes hypocritical when it turns the result of competition into a complete explanation of a person's worth. The winner is told that they deserved everything. The person left behind is told that the result describes their character. Luck, inheritance, illness, infrastructure, and circumstance disappear from the story just when they should be analyzed.

Not all resentment produced this way is justified. Envy exists, as does refusal of responsibility and the interpretation of every difference as an insult. But neither can we invalidate a grievance merely because it is voiced angrily. A system that closes access while continuing to preach open competition manufactures credible opponents for itself.

The answer should not be to abolish merit but to be modest about the meritocratic explanation. We can value a result without pretending to know how much of it comes from effort, chance, or invisible support. We can preserve differentiated rewards while limiting the inheritance of disproportionate political power. We can protect economic initiative without turning ownership into a title of human superiority.

Liberal democracy need not be abandoned because it does not fully fulfill its promise. Research on the relationship between democratization and economic growth itself offers empirical reasons to reject the idea that authoritarianism has general economic superiority. Acemoglu and colleagues identify favorable long-term effects of democratization within their estimation strategy; the result does not guarantee the success of every democracy. [13]

The ladder exists. Sometimes it is more accessible than ever before. But a society cannot demand trust merely by pointing to a few people who have climbed it. It must also show who controls the rungs, who can add others, and who has the right to pull them away after reaching the top.

PART II — FREEDOM AGAINST ITSELF

CHAPTER 5

The Censorship That Does Not Forbid You to Speak

Freedom of expression can survive legally in an environment where expression no longer produces attention, understanding, or accountability.

Four Ways to Make Truth Ineffective

The first mechanism is prohibition: you may not publish, or you are threatened, punished, or blocked from distributing your work. The second is dependency: you may publish, but funding, access to sources, or promotion push you toward certain subjects and away from others. The third is drowning out: the information exists, but it is buried beneath a volume that exceeds the capacity to examine it. The fourth is fragmentation: people encounter incompatible fragments without a common framework for checking and deciding.

Only the first corresponds straightforwardly to censorship in its strict sense. For the others, “censorship by noise” is a functional analogy: the result may be a truth's inability to change power, but the mechanism and remedy differ. If every lack of an audience is called censorship, the concept ceases to distinguish a political crime from a conversation no one wants to hear.

Djankov and colleagues' comparative study of media ownership shows the importance of state control and concentrated ownership, including family ownership. It does not follow that every newsroom is merely a mouthpiece or that all owners act in concert. Editorial independence, competition, and funding structures must be investigated, not assumed either absent or present. [14]

A Conspiracy Is Not Necessary for a Toxic Result

Imagine a platform that profits when users stay longer. Each team optimizes a local metric. Creators learn what attracts reactions. The public adjusts its expectations. No participant need intend to degrade public discourse for the system as a whole to do so. This is a possible emergent mechanism, not proof that every platform works identically.

Deliberate forms of distraction also exist. King, Pan, and Roberts analyzed the coordinated production of pro-government messages in China's online environment and found a strong emphasis on shifting attention, rather than arguing directly with opponents. The study concerns a particular operation and context; it does not justify turning the entire internet into a single conspiracy, nor does it remove the role of direct repression. [15]

Power does not always need to be believed. Sometimes it is enough that no one believes verification is worth the effort. If every scandal is met with ten more, the cost of establishing responsibility can exceed the public energy available. This is a hypothesis about a mechanism: it should be tested through effects on attention, knowledge, and political sanctions, not deduced merely from our irritation with social networks.

Algorithms Matter, but Not in the Same Way Everywhere

Experimental results do not support a single story. Guess and colleagues replaced participants' algorithmic Facebook and Instagram feeds with chronological ones in the context of the 2020 U.S. election. Exposure and use changed, but the study did not detect corresponding changes in the political attitudes it tracked. A null result from a bounded intervention does not demonstrate the absence of any effect of platforms. [16]

A study published by Gauthier and colleagues in 2026, based on a seven-week experiment conducted on X in 2023, found that enabling the algorithmic feed for users of the chronological feed shifted some views in a conservative direction. Disabling it did not produce a symmetric effect; significant effects were not detected on every measure, including partisan identification. The authors also examine the persistence of newly followed accounts. [17]

The lesson is not that an algorithm can produce any opinion on command. It is that the platform, the period, prior exposure, and the variable measured all matter. A clear-eyed project must be able to say both “causal effects have been demonstrated under certain conditions” and “we do not know how to generalize these effects automatically to society as a whole.”

Who Filters the Filter?

An apparently simple remedy would be to replace commercial optimization with optimization for the public good. But who defines the public good? A ministry? A committee of experts? The platform owner, transformed into a moral educator? Each solution can recreate exactly the authority it claims to restrain.

A more prudent alternative is pluralism among selection tools: users should be able to change their filter, compare sources, understand the main criteria, and take their relationships to another service. Funding for public-interest journalism should reduce dependence on any one patron, including a government patron. Audits should examine procedures and effects without becoming a political license to determine truth.

Not even these measures solve the finitude of attention. Not everyone will read the important documents. Not every problem will receive attention proportionate to its severity. The realistic objective is not equal distribution of audience, but credible paths by which verified information can reach institutions obliged to respond. The freedom to shout becomes civic power only when someone can legitimately be required to listen and give reasons.

CHAPTER 6

Who Has the Right to Say What Is Good for Us?

Collective decision-making requires a rule. No rule eliminates conflict among preferences, knowledge, and rights.

Society Does Not Have a Single Utility Function

A dam can produce energy and destroy a local ecosystem. A housing policy can lower costs for newcomers and diminish the advantage of existing owners. A security rule can reduce one risk and expand surveillance. The word “optimal” conceals questions about who gains, who loses, and what we refuse to exchange for other benefits.

There is no purely technical operation that can turn everyone's preferences, dignities, and risks into one uncontroversial number. We can construct useful indicators. But choosing them involves value judgments. Maximizing an indicator does not eliminate politics: it moves politics into the indicator's definition and the distribution of weights.

Arrow's theorem shows that certain precise requirements for aggregating individual preferences into a social ordering are incompatible when there are at least three alternatives and a sufficiently broad domain of preferences. The relevant conditions include nondictatorship, respect for unanimity, and independence of irrelevant alternatives. It does not say that elections are useless, all rules are the same, or a dictator would know the public interest. [18]

We can see a simpler difficulty in a constructed example. Three groups rank policies as follows: the first prefers A over B and B over C; the second prefers B over C and C over A; the third prefers C over A and A over B. A majority prefers A to B, B to C, and C to A. Each group has coherent preferences, but the majority comparisons form a cycle. The order of the questions can affect the result.

Expertise Does Not Eliminate Conflict

An expert can say that a bridge will not hold. It does not follow that the expert alone may decide which community must be moved to build another. Expertise is authority over certain inferences and methods, not an unlimited mandate over the ends of collective life.

The opposite populist problem is just as real. A vote cannot make a structure safe or alter a physical constraint. A majority can choose an objective, but it cannot abolish its costs. A democracy that treats expertise as just another opinion sabotages its ability to act. A technocracy that treats values as mere public errors sabotages its legitimacy.

A better division of labor would ask experts to delineate feasible options, uncertainties, and likely effects, and the political process to justify the choice among interests. In practice, the boundary is imperfect: what data we collect depends on what we care about, and what we learn can change our preferences. That is why the roles must converse, not be separated by an imaginary wall.

In a formal model, Sen showed the tension between certain minimal rights of individual choice and the Pareto principle when other people's preferences may include what you do. The result does not prohibit liberalism. It shows that intrusive preferences and the idea that every unanimously preferred improvement must be accepted do not combine easily with certain conceptions of liberty. [19]

Pluralism Has a Time for Debate and a Time for Decision

An institution cannot consult forever without deciding. There are deadlines, resources being consumed, and dangers that grow worse. But urgency can also be manufactured to eliminate opposition. The answer is neither endless deliberation nor a leader who declares permanently that there is no more time.

We can separate the stages. Before a decision: public alternatives, adversarial analysis, representation of those affected, and disclosure of uncertainty. At the decision: an identifiable authority, a deadline, and explicit reasons. After it: measuring consequences, a possibility of appeal, and rules for revision. This structure does not eliminate loss; it makes loss less arbitrary.

Not every project must be decided by referendum, and not every disagreement requires consensus. Some rights function precisely as limits on what a majority may sacrifice for aggregate benefit. Rawls offers an important normative justification for the priority of basic liberties, fair equality of opportunity, and assessing inequalities by a principle other than arithmetic equalization. This is not an empirical theorem that every policy adopted in the name of these principles works. [8]

The possible light is not the discovery of a mind that knows what is optimal for everyone. It is building a procedure in which no one can completely hide who pays for their own “optimum.” Pluralism becomes paralysis when there are no rules for bringing a decision to a close. Authority becomes domination when closing a decision also closes the right to challenge it.

CHAPTER 7

Resentment: Who Produces It and Who Organizes It

A society needs aspiration. When it produces more promises of status than credible positions, aspiration can turn into hostility.

The Elite Is Not One Person

The word “elite” can refer to highly competent people, very wealthy people, holders of decisive offices, or groups that control access to prestige. These categories overlap only in part. An outstanding researcher may have little political power. A mediocre intermediary may control the careers of much more capable people. Without this distinction, criticism of elites oscillates between egalitarianism and resentment without identifying its target.

“Elite overproduction” is a hypothesis associated, among others, with Peter Turchin's research program: growth in the number of aspirants to dominant positions relative to the positions available may fuel conflict within elites and instability. His 2010 Nature text is a short predictive intervention, not in itself a statistical demonstration of a universal mechanism. [20]

The intuition deserves to be taken seriously without becoming historical astrology. Not every university graduate is an aspiring oligarch. Not every intense competition among professionals destabilizes the state. Testing the hypothesis requires defining the positions, measuring expectations, and showing the mechanism by which frustration becomes political organization. Otherwise, any protest by educated people can be reinterpreted retrospectively as confirmation.

A plausible extension concerns the social promise of recognition. If education is sold as almost guaranteed access to a respected life, while markets and institutions mainly offer insecurity, the problem is not reducible to income. A person may feel deceived about their identity. Not all such expectations are reasonable; nevertheless, the institutions that cultivated them cannot pretend they did not contribute to the outcome.

There Is No Homogeneous Poor Class Hostile to Culture

The claim that poorer groups traditionally hate culture, rules, or the middle class is too broad to serve as an explanation. It confuses the actual conduct of some people and groups with the supposed essence of a class. It may also confuse rejection of a culture perceived as a badge of social superiority with rejection of knowledge in general.

Anti-intellectualism exists, as do hostility toward rules and pleasure in humiliating competent people. So do contempt cultivated by elites toward people in modest occupations, sophisticated cynicism, and rule-breaking by perfectly educated means. Neither refined vocabulary nor wealth guarantees civic conduct. We must investigate behavior and institutions, not infer character from a person's income.

A middle class may fear excessive taxation, the loss of public services, and declining professional status at the same time. A poor person may demand protection and support policies that reduce it if those policies offer identity or respect. A major property owner may finance anti-establishment rhetoric without wanting to lose their advantages. All are logically possible combinations; how frequent they are in a particular context must be established separately.

For that reason, the formula “the elites above manipulate the poor against the middle class” is one possible mechanism, not an exhaustive map of politics. Sometimes the alliance runs the other way. Sometimes protest expresses a genuine abuse the middle class does not see. Sometimes the political entrepreneur does not invent the conflict but changes its target and organizes its energy.

From Grievance to Authoritarianism

Resentment becomes a resource of domination when it is linked to a recognizable culprit and a promise to restore dignity by subjugating someone else. It is no longer enough for us to live better; they must lose. In this structure, even a leader's material failure may be tolerated so long as the leader keeps humiliating the desired adversary.

But clinical terms should not be used as universal explanations. Calling every demagogue a “psychopath” may express outrage without identifying the mechanism. People without a psychiatric diagnosis can pursue power brutally, and poorly organized institutions can amplify ordinary opportunism. Analysis must describe lies, intimidation, corruption, and their incentives, rather than replace politics with diagnoses from a distance.

Graham and Svolik's study shows, through experiments on candidate choice, that partisan attachment can reduce some voters' willingness to punish undemocratic behavior by their own representatives. The result warns that support for democracy can be conditional; it is not proof that a social class or biological group is incompatible with democracy. [21]

The lasting answer is not to eliminate ambition. It is to multiply legitimate forms of success and reduce the situations in which losing a competition means social exclusion. A society with a single ladder of prestige and a single gateway to security creates a more dangerous struggle for the top. A plurality of vocations does not abolish envy, but it can reduce the total stakes of a single social verdict.

At the same time, institutions must sanction the exploitation of resentment when it turns into threats, fraud, or violence. Understanding a frustration does not mean legitimizing every project born from it. A clear-eyed politics must be able to say both: the grievance is real; the proposed solution is abusive.

CHAPTER 8

Can Freedom Choose Its Own End?

Democracy must tolerate challenges. It is not obliged to provide the means to destroy the possibility of challenging it irreversibly.

Rights Are Not the Wages of Exemplary Citizenship

Freedom also protects those who do not use it admirably. Someone may be superficial, malicious, uninformed, or unable to understand a complex question and still have the right not to be tortured, to defend themselves in court, and to criticize power. These rights are not a reward for excellence. They are limits imposed on those who might turn an assessment of a person into a license to dominate.

The phrase “unjustified rights” must be unpacked. Some particular claims may be excessive, incompatible with others' rights, or impossible to finance. But it does not follow that legal equality itself is a mistake. Asking for a social policy to be justified is not the same as asking someone to prove their biological worth in order to remain a citizen.

There is a serious objection: political decisions have consequences for everyone, and voters' competence varies. Should better-informed people not have more influence? In certain roles, we already demand verified competence. We do not choose a surgeon by lottery. But governing is not a single technical operation, and selecting those who would receive a “more valuable” vote is itself a political decision.

A civic exam can measure some kinds of knowledge. It does not automatically measure good faith, resistance to self-interest, or the ability to represent experiences the candidate does not share. The committee can be captured. The syllabus can confuse conformity with intelligence. Those excluded become subjects of a rule they can no longer change. We have not eliminated the problem of competence; we have concentrated it in a vulnerable gateway.

Freedom Needs Capabilities, Not Only Restraints on the State

A citizen who is formally free but unable to read a contract, identify a source, or survive an employer's refusal has fragile freedom. Protecting freedom therefore also means developing the capabilities to use it. Education, accessible information, a minimum of time for participation, and the material ability to say no can serve constitutional, not merely social, purposes.

Pettit describes freedom as nondomination: the problem is not merely actual interference, but also dependence on arbitrary power. A master who chooses to be generous does not thereby cease to be a master. This is a useful normative perspective for assessing both the state and private power. [9]

Yet developing capabilities must not mean manufacturing people who think correctly by the government's standard. Civic education needs procedural criteria: how to check a claim, distinguish disagreement from a threat, justify a rule, and accept losing a decision without surrendering the right to challenge it. It fails when loyalty to a party becomes the measure of maturity.

Freedom does not reproduce itself. This is an institutional conclusion, not a genetic condemnation of the population. Every generation must learn the costs of cooperation, the limits of power, and the discipline of living together. No excellent constitution can fully replace those practices. But neither does their absence justify handing society over to an unchecked guardian.

Democratic Self-Defense and the Policing of Opinions

The risk is not merely an abstract possibility. In its report on 2025 results, published in March 2026, V-Dem identifies erosion in some established democracies, pressure on freedom of expression, and weakening checks on power. The same source also identifies countries undergoing democratization. These assessments support the existence of a contemporary risk, not the inevitability of one direction or an explanation based on a single cause. The indicators depend on definitions and measurement procedures that must be examined, not turned into metaphysical verdicts. [47]

An open system can encounter organizations that use freedom to eliminate their opponents' freedom. To answer that any restriction would betray democracy is naive. To answer that every radical opinion should be prohibited is the beginning of another, more dangerous naivety: confidence that those in power will always apply the label of extremism correctly.

This book proposes separating opinion, political organization, and coercive conduct. A deeply unpopular idea should not be equated with an assault. Threats, covert financing of violence, electoral intimidation, and deliberate destruction of the mechanisms for changing governments, however, require intervention. Any restriction must have a precise object, evidence, proportionality, and an independent route of appeal. These are design principles, not a summary of any jurisdiction's law.

A difficult area remains: an adversary may act legally, gradually changing the rules until competition disappears. That is precisely why the distribution of power among institutions, transparency of funding, and protection of the opposition's ability to organize matter. Democracy cannot be reduced to counting votes on the day the authorities still allow ballot boxes to remain open.

The antinomy is not resolved by an infallible guardian. It is managed through reciprocal limits and a public criterion: a self-defense measure is suspect when it grants the ruler a permanent advantage and weakens the possibility of replacing them. The defense of freedom must be judged, among other things, by the freedom to challenge those who claim to defend it.

CHAPTER 9

Demography Is Not a Verdict on Human Worth

Differences among people and changes in population can matter politically. They do not authorize the leap from bounded correlations to biological castes and a supposedly inevitable democratic fate.

An Uncomfortable Hypothesis Deserves Testing, Not Consecration

The hypothesis at the starting point of this book can be reconstructed as follows: some traits that favor learning, self-control, or cooperation are distributed unequally; certain groups with lower levels of these traits have more children; the population's composition changes; democracy loses the civic capacity it needs to survive. The chain is intelligible as a hypothesis. Each arrow, however, requires distinct evidence.

The traits must be defined and measured without confusing them with income or diplomas, their transmission explained, their environments assessed, and their connection with civic behavior shown. We must also distinguish completed fertility from the age at which people have children, differences between the sexes from aggregate averages, and rapid cultural change from slow genetic change. A coherent story does not meet these conditions by itself.

There is research relevant to one part of the hypothesis. In an Icelandic sample, Kong and colleagues found an association between a polygenic score related to educational attainment, later reproduction, and having fewer children. The authors discuss implications of selection on the measured variants. The result is not a ranking of religions or classes by biological status and does not directly measure civic conscience. [23]

It would be unscientific to hide such a finding because it is uncomfortable. It would be equally unscientific to use it as sufficient proof of the inevitable decline of a civilization. An educational score is not identical to intelligence, intelligence is not identical to discipline, and discipline is not identical to respect for another person's freedom.

Heritable Does Not Mean Immutable, Nor Does It Automatically Explain Differences Between Groups

A variation can have a hereditary component within a population and an environment without the difference between two populations having the same explanation. The logic is simple: the causes of differences among individuals within one set of conditions are not necessarily the causes of differences between two sets of conditions. Confusing these levels produces conclusions that appear biological but rest on faulty inferences.

Within-family genetic analyses matter precisely because they reduce some sources of confounding present in comparisons among unrelated people. Howe and colleagues show that estimates of certain direct genetic effects change when sibling comparisons are used, with implications for the role of population structure and family effects. This does not refute genetics; it makes genetic inference more demanding. [26]

More directly relevant to the story of general decline, Bratsberg and Rogeberg analyzed cognitive scores for cohorts of Norwegian men. Both the rise and the reversal of the trend appeared in within-family comparisons. For the pattern observed in those data, this result contradicts an explanation based simply on changes in population composition between families. It does not prove that every cognitive change everywhere is exclusively environmental. [24]

Ritchie and Tucker-Drob synthesized quasi-experimental research and found positive effects of education on intelligence scores, with estimates varying across models and contexts. Education is therefore not merely a passive certificate of capacities fixed in advance. Their result also does not mean every educational program produces the same increase or that effects can be extrapolated linearly forever. [25]

Religion and Culture Are Not Genotypes

Religious and cultural norms can influence reproductive decisions, education, relationships with authority, and family roles. These are legitimate subjects for analysis. But religious affiliation does not identify a person's intellectual level or establish a uniform biological strategy. Internal diversity, generational change, and social conditions cannot be erased with a label.

The OECD's Society at a Glance 2024 report discusses fertility in relation to factors including costs, economic security, housing, norms, and the possibility of combining working and family life. That is incompatible with reducing the explanation to some people's mere negligence and others' superiority. It does not eliminate individual responsibility or claim that any public intervention can easily change birth rates. [44]

Nor is poverty a genetic test. A person can achieve poor results for very different reasons, and the same results can conceal different capabilities. Moreover, the social order decides which capabilities it rewards. An ability valued in one environment can remain invisible in another. Inferring biological worth from economic success inserts into the conclusion the very social hierarchy we claim to explain.

What, Then, Is the Real Risk?

The plausible risk is institutional and intergenerational: if a society fails to develop basic competencies, reduce the costs of exclusion, and prevent political entrepreneurs from rewarding hostility, it may reproduce conduct incompatible with democratic cooperation. This mechanism does not require denying individual differences. It only requires us not to use those differences as a shortcut to an unproven collective destiny.

Justifiable policy concerns early education, support for child care, voluntary access to reproductive health care, parental responsibility, and equal enforcement of rules. Assessment must concern observable effects, not conformity with an ideal of the biological citizen. Children are not guilty of their parents' circumstances, and reproductive rights cannot become rewards distributed by a committee judging human worth.

This limit is not a cosmetic treatment of reality. It follows realistically from the question: who would receive the power to classify, by what criteria, and with what possibility of appeal? An elite that claims the right to control others' reproduction has resolved the antinomy of equality in the oldest way: by declaring itself entitled to dominate.

From the research discussed here, we have no demonstration that liberal democracy is doomed by the fertility of “inferior” groups. We have evidence that human traits have complex causes and that institutions cannot treat the development of capabilities as a detail. Saying more than the data permit is not courage. It lends borrowed certainty to an explanation that has not earned it.

PART III — HOW FAR CAN WE DISPERSE POWER?

CHAPTER 10

Why No “Ism” Works All the Way Through

A doctrine becomes dangerous when it turns a useful principle into an excuse for overlooking the costs of applying it.

The Best Defense of Libertarianism

Libertarianism asks a question every collective project should be able to answer: by what right do you compel me? Before celebrating a policy's goal, we must justify the means by which a person's resources, work, and freedom are mobilized. A generous cause does not automatically confer an unlimited claim on others. Nozick's arguments for moral constraints on the use of persons and for a minimal state are one influential formulation, not the only version of this tradition. [46]

The force of this warning appears whenever a bureaucrat treats the population as material to be optimized. It also appears when a majority votes for a burden that will be borne almost entirely by an unpopular minority. Libertarianism is right to reject the idea that merely aggregating preferences confers moral legitimacy on every intervention.

Its difficulty begins when contractual voluntariness is detached from its conditions. You may accept a contract because it benefits you. You may also accept because every credible alternative has been closed. Not every inequality in bargaining power invalidates consent, but a signature does not automatically settle the problem of domination either. Who defined property, who defends it, and what costs are borne by nonparticipants remain political questions.

A society of contracts needs rules about harm, children, inability to consent, common resources, and conflicts among jurisdictions. If a public authority enforces these rules, we return to the problem of limiting the state. If private providers alone enforce them, we return to the problem of the strongest provider and of people unable to refuse its terms. The absence of political vocabulary does not eliminate a political function.

The strongest defense of socialism

Socialism starts with another indispensable question: how free is someone who depends on another's property to live? It observes that production is often collective while its results and control can be distributed asymmetrically. It is not absurd to demand a say in decisions that organize a large part of our lives.

A democratic form of socialism must not be confused with a party monopoly. We can imagine worker-owned firms, diversified social funds, and public services with professional autonomy within robust political freedoms. These mechanisms must be evaluated separately. Dismissing them by merely invoking the historical political police would substitute an association for an argument.

The difficulty appears when common ownership is treated as sufficient to solve the problem of representation. A good may formally belong to everyone while being controlled in practice by its administrators. Everyone's participation in every decision is costly. Delegation rebuilds a hierarchy. Protecting existing workers may block entry by others. Equalizing rewards may weaken some incentives. None of these difficulties rules out common ownership; all require additional mechanisms.

There is also a risk of scale: eliminating private centers of power may concentrate enough authority in one public center that challenging it becomes nearly impossible. Counterpower is not dispensable because the administrator speaks in everyone's name.

The strongest defense of classical liberalism

Classical liberalism protects a plurality of lives and limits an authority's claim to know how everyone should live. Mill argues for individual liberty and the value of confronting opinions without treating every action affecting someone else as immune from rules. The tradition is not a single formula and does not equate to an absent state in all its versions. [45]

Its strength lies in modesty: we can cooperate without agreeing on life's ultimate purpose. There need not be a single kind of good person, a single culture, or a single moral community. Protecting this diversity has value that cannot be reduced to efficiency.

Its weakness appears when the material and institutional conditions of freedom are assumed already to exist. A person dominated economically, a community deprived of information, or a public sphere controlled by a few intermediaries is not emancipated merely by a formal ban on state intervention. Liberalism needs institutions that prevent some people's liberty from becoming others' dependence.

On the other hand, when it tries to create those conditions, it approaches redistributive, regulatory, and educational policies that some of its supporters already consider excessive. This is not necessarily a fatal contradiction. It is a sign that negative liberty, effective capacity, and the prevention of domination do not coincide perfectly.

A mixture is not automatically wisdom

Saying that we need markets, the state, and communities solves nothing unless we specify where each begins and ends. A mixed system can combine the advantages of these mechanisms. It can also combine their defects: private profit, public loss, and communities used to cover unpaid labor.

The defensible conclusion is not that no 'ism' makes sense. Each identifies a real problem and offers partial tools. The conclusion is that none is a complete algorithm for governance independent of context. The more a doctrine claims to solve every case with one principle, the more carefully we must examine what it has left out of its description.

The common test will be the same: does it distribute the ability to refuse? Does it make the administrator replaceable? Does it let uncomfortable information circulate? Does it permit correction without catastrophe? Does it recognize costs shifted onto those without a voice? No tradition owns all the good answers to these questions.

CHAPTER 11

Cosmolocalism: the promise and the bill

Knowledge can circulate globally while production moves closer to communities. Neither open knowledge nor proximity creates freedom by itself.

What this idea changes

Cosmolocalism proposes a combination different from the simple alternative between centralized globalization and local withdrawal: global sharing of knowledge, designs, and experience, with local production and adaptation where feasible. Schismenos, Niaros, and Lemos discuss it in relation to the commons and democratic forms of organization. The concept is a program of transformation and investigation, not a system of governance validated at every scale. [27]

The European COSMOLOCALISM project investigated precisely the connection between global design and local production. The existence of such a program and concrete initiatives provides objects of study. It does not prove that the formula can replace the state, global infrastructure, or every industrial supply chain. [28]

A constructed example makes the promise intelligible. Several communities contribute to an open design for water-treatment equipment. Changes are documented; tests can be repeated; local workshops produce or assemble components suited to their conditions. Knowledge need not be reinvented in every locality, and dependence on one supplier may fall. The benefit is not absolute self-sufficiency, but an expanded local capacity to understand, repair, and negotiate.

This example does not claim that any such equipment is safe or that every workshop can make it. Certification, accountability, competence, and supply remain necessary. An open file is not a factory, and a public diagram is not a quality guarantee.

Commons need governance

Ostrom showed that the management of common resources need not be reduced to a choice between privatization and central command. Polycentric institutions and context-sensitive rules can sustain cooperation. The importance of monitoring, sanctions, and organization at several levels contradicts the picture of the commons as a rule-free space based entirely on goodwill. [22]

The opportunistic contributor does not disappear. Who pays for maintenance? Who is responsible for a defect? Who decides whether a change is integrated? Who can withdraw the rights of an administrator sabotaging the project? If the real answer is 'the same three people, because only they understand the system,' there is a center of power even if the code repository is public.

Legal openness must be complemented by practical accessibility. Incomprehensible documentation, missing tools, certification costs, and concentrated reputation can make it impossible to fork a project. Being able to copy a file is not the same as being able to continue a service. Decentralization must be measured by viable alternatives, not the number of copies of a license.

A study by Uchiyama on ridesharing examines the tension between shared resources and their enclosure by platforms. It is useful precisely because it discusses capture in a concrete field, not because it proves cosmolocalism generally superior. [43]

The local can be close and suffocating

A small community may see its members' needs more clearly. It may also punish difference more effectively. Reputation, access to services, work, and family relationships can be controlled by the same network. In a large city, anonymity can protect. In a close community, nobody may allow you to be different.

Bardhan and Mookherjee analyze the risk of capture at local and national levels. The important point is that decentralization does not have one universal effect: it depends on the distribution of influence and on institutional conditions. Proximity to decision-makers may aid accountability or intensify dependence. [29]

Cosmolocalism therefore needs rights that cannot be negotiated separately by each community. A person must be able to seek protection outside the local circle. Exit must be possible without confiscation of identity, savings, or essential relationships. Portability of social rights and access to an independent arbiter are not optional bureaucratic extras; they are part of local freedom.

The physical limits of a beautiful idea

Not everything should be produced locally. Some processes require scale, specialization, scarce raw materials, and long-distance coordination. Duplicating every capacity in every community may consume more resources and reduce quality. Proximity is a possible criterion, not a virtue that cancels the energy and material balance.

A more realistic formula is tested subsidiarity: a task remains at the closest level able to carry it out competently without exporting unacceptable costs. Water crossing several regions, epidemics, and some infrastructure require institutions above the local level. Everyday adaptation can remain local within common obligations.

The promise of cosmolocalism is therefore limited but important: it can broaden functional ownership of the capacities of life. It does not promise that every community will be good, that scale no longer matters, or that politics dissolves into cooperation. Giving up precisely these promises may turn it from a utopian image into a serious direction.

CHAPTER 12

Who holds the weapon, and who can tell them to put it down?

A decentralized order needs common defense. Common defense can produce the very center of power the order sought to escape.

The problem protocols do not solve

A community may have impeccable governance and be attacked by one that respects no rules. A federation may have excellent contracts and encounter an actor who sees the contract as the adversary's weakness. Neither transparency nor good faith obliges an aggressor to cooperate.

This is the strongest objection to the dream of decentralization without common sovereignty. If every unit must defend itself, the weak become dependent on protectors. If they pool their defense, an organization with disproportionate resources and authority emerges. If that organization also controls funding, information, and access to technology, it may become the new de facto sovereign center.

Weber identifies the modern state by its successful claim to a monopoly on the legitimate use of physical force within a territory. The definition does not mean that the central government carries out every act of force directly or that every state use of force is morally justified. It shows the importance of the authority that decides who may use coercion legitimately. [31]

Tilly examines the historical connection among war, resource extraction, and state formation. His analysis explains particular historical processes, especially European ones; it is not a theorem that every defensive cooperation inevitably produces dictatorship. War can build state apparatuses, but it can also destroy states. [30]

The monopoly of force must not be confused with a monopoly on all decisions

The constructive question is whether authority over force can be sufficiently unified to protect and sufficiently distributed not to dominate. There is no absolute guarantee. There are, however, institutional distinctions concealed by the formula 'a center or anarchy.'

Operational command, legal authorization, the budget, procurement oversight, and evaluation of abuses need not be concentrated in the same person or organization. A defensive structure can have clear command without unlimited authority to decide who the enemy is, how long an emergency lasts, and which rights disappear. The distribution of oversight must be designed before a crisis, not negotiated after force has been mobilized.

Distributed oversight is not innocent either. Too many vetoes can paralyze a response. Too much immediate transparency can compromise protection. Separation must therefore operate at the appropriate levels: authorization, objectives, limits, and accountability, without turning every professional action into a plebiscite. Temporary secrecy may be justified; permanent immunity from oversight is not.

The proposal concerns institutions, not technical mechanisms for using weapons. The central rule is that no part of the coercive apparatus should be able to change on its own the mandate from which it draws authority. This is a difficult constitutional goal, not a property a document can impose by itself.

Crisis is the moment of truth

Any decentralized order must be tested under adverse conditions: external attack, infrastructure sabotage, a region unable to contribute, and a majority demanding the exclusion of a minority. A constitution that functions only without danger is more a code of manners.

Exceptional powers may be necessary. They must have a bounded purpose, limited duration, verifiable justification, and renewal by actors other than the beneficiary of their expansion. Later oversight must be able to produce consequences, not merely a report. People who report abuses need protection, and compensation for victims must not depend on the administration's gratitude.

Even these rules can in practice be suspended by a sufficiently powerful coalition. Here the limit of any architecture becomes visible: its application depends on people and organizations with the capacity and interest to defend it. There is no constitution that executes itself in the physical world.

Distributed-ledger technologies can make certain changes more visible and verify certain authorizations. They cannot determine on their own whether an accusation is true, a decision is just, or an armed actor will obey a rule. Cryptography protects defined properties of information; it does not turn justice into a consequence of software consensus.

Can we avoid the return of empire?

A cosmolocal federation would have to combine a shared capacity for protection with an economic and information base sufficiently plural to limit seizure of the center. If all revenue, all communication, and all AI systems depend on the same defensive authority, separation of powers on paper becomes fragile.

But there is a cost: redundancy, verification, and distributed capacities may be more expensive than centralization. Freedom is not always the option with the lowest administrative bill. It may be an investment in the ability to refuse an abusive command without the whole society collapsing.

We cannot demonstrate that radical decentralization will solve the monopoly of violence. We can show, more modestly, why a project that ignores the problem is incomplete. The light is not the disappearance of force but a lower chance that protection becomes the protector's property. That chance will not reach zero. The political question is whether we can make it small enough, and the consequences reversible enough, for freedom to be worth the risk.

CHAPTER 13

Dark Enlightenment: freedom for whom?

Exit from a jurisdiction can limit power. It does not replace the right to contest power for those who cannot leave.

The surface resemblance

Some projects of democratic localism and some projects of private sovereignty criticize the same object: the large, rigid, opaque state that is hard to change. Both may speak of smaller units, competition, experimentation, and the ability to leave. But similar vocabulary can conceal opposed distributions of authority.

In a democratic cosmolocal project, those affected must have rights over the rules and relevant commons. In a project of proprietary sovereignty, ultimate decision-making power may belong to the jurisdiction's owner. The first seeks to distribute authority. The second seeks to make it more coherent through concentration and to discipline it through competition among territories.

In Patchwork, Curtis Yarvin, writing under the pseudonym Mencius Moldbug, imagines jurisdictions governed on proprietary and corporate lines. In The Dark Enlightenment, Nick Land develops a radical critique of democracy and gives exit from political orders an important role. These are primary political texts, useful for understanding the doctrines, not scientific evidence of their effectiveness. [32, 33]

In his 2009 essay The Education of a Libertarian, Peter Thiel expresses doubt about the compatibility of freedom and democracy and explores exits from ordinary politics. This text documents an influential author's position. It does not permit attributing the same doctrine to every technology entrepreneur or very wealthy person. [34]

The argument worth confronting

The strongest version of the proprietary argument concerns incentives. An owner would have an interest in maintaining the jurisdiction's value, attracting residents and capital, and reducing disorder. Electoral government, by contrast, may reward short-term thinking, unfunded promises, and diffused accountability among many actors. That is not an absurd objection.

Moreover, institutional experimentation in a small unit may be less risky than changing an entire state at once. The ability to compare regimes and leave may discipline administrators. A well-bounded contract can provide predictability an arbitrary administration does not offer.

The problem is that a jurisdiction is not a hotel. A resident may have children, real estate, dependent relatives, a regulated profession, and relationships that are hard to move. The cost of leaving may rise because of the owner's own decisions. If all alternatives use similar models or require entry capital, formal competition does not produce effective exit.

Nor is maximizing value identical to protecting every resident. The owner may prefer to replace people who generate less revenue. They may shift costs onto neighbors. They may restrict criticism that threatens the investment's reputation. These are incentive possibilities, not factual accusations against every concrete project. They show why commercial discipline is not a complete substitute for rights.

A contract cannot contain the person definitively

An adult may voluntarily accept strict rules within a community. But freedom of association does not justify irrevocably giving up protection against abuse. Nor does it produce the consent of children subsequently born there or of people affected outside it. Every contractual order encounters, at the contract's edge, the politics it thought it had surpassed.

If an owner is limited by a higher constitution, independent courts, and rights that cannot be withdrawn, the project can be evaluated as a form of local administration. But its sovereignty is no longer absolute. If it refuses these limits, residents risk receiving quality services in exchange for losing their status as co-authors of the rules.

Efficient domination remains domination. It may be preferable to inefficient domination in some tragic circumstances, but it does not thereby become an ideal of freedom. The phrase 'you can leave' does not mean the same thing to someone with mobile capital and someone whose life is rooted in a place.

Justified suspicion and an unhelpful caricature

Suspicion of proprietary localism is justified when decentralization on the map conceals centralization within each territory. More small sovereigns do not automatically mean more freedom for every person. We can have a market of micro-autocracies and very little everyday autonomy.

Yet criticism should not turn every experiment in private administration into a totalitarian project. Residents' rights, applicable jurisdiction, appeal mechanisms, contractual transparency, and the actual cost of exit matter. Evaluation through mechanisms is stronger than guilt by association with a controversial name.

The useful dividing line is this: the cosmolocalism pursued here does not try to find better owners for society. It tries to reduce the number of situations in which society has owners. It can retain firms, markets, and contracts. It must not turn a person into a customer whose final protection depends on commercial value.

PART IV — ABUNDANCE AND THE POWER TO SAY NO

CHAPTER 14

Artificial intelligence does not abolish political economy

AI can distribute expertise. It can also concentrate the infrastructure through which expertise becomes useful.

Exposure to automation is not the disappearance of work

An occupation is a bundle of tasks, relationships, and responsibilities. A system's ability to generate the text of a report does not mean it can fully assume the accountability, negotiation, and verification associated with a profession. Conversely, the fact that some tasks resist automation does not guarantee that the number of jobs and bargaining power will remain unchanged.

The ILO's 2025 report on occupational exposure to generative AI distinguishes the potential for transformation from the complete replacement of occupations. Exposure indices describe the compatibility of certain tasks with the technology; they are not mechanical predictions of layoffs. Adoption, costs, institutions, and the reorganization of work mediate the effects. [35]

Brynjolfsson, Li, and Raymond studied the introduction of an AI assistant in a customer-support setting and found productivity gains, with larger benefits for less experienced workers. The result shows one possible mechanism for spreading skills. It does not demonstrate that AI reduces every inequality, that all occupations are comparable, or that owners will distribute the benefits proportionately. [36]

The book therefore does not assume that human labor will disappear on a known date. It examines scenarios. In one, AI complements work and lowers some barriers to entry. In another, it replaces enough tasks that a substantial part of the population loses bargaining power. In a third, highly advanced capabilities are concentrated and the owners' advantage becomes hard to challenge. These paths can combine and change.

The same productivity, three political orders

Imagine a hypothetical economy in which AI and robotics greatly increase material capacity. In the first version, a small number of companies own the infrastructure. The population's income depends on remaining wages and transfers negotiated with the state. In the second, a centralized public apparatus owns the infrastructure. People receive services, but their access to production may be administratively mediated. In the third, ownership is plural: competing firms, cooperatives, social funds, and local capacities.

These are analytical scenarios, not forecasts. They show that the same technical possibility is compatible with different distributions of power. Productivity tells us how much can be produced under certain conditions. It does not tell us who decides distribution, who can refuse, or what happens to a dissenter.

A future nomenklatura need not carry party membership cards. It might control access to models, computing power, digital identity, certification, and distribution channels. Likewise, a public authority may become indispensable because it alone provides safe infrastructure. Changing the public–private label does not by itself resolve dependence.

Opening models is therefore important but insufficient. Model weights available without energy, hardware, operational expertise, and lawful access to data may represent more a symbolic possibility than effective autonomy. Conversely, technical centralization does not always produce domination if alternatives, interoperability, and enforceable legal limits exist. The concentration of usable capacity must be measured, not merely the number of published projects.

AI as a tool of governance and a tool of control

An AI system can help compare budgets, identify inconsistencies, access procedures, and analyze volumes of information that citizens cannot examine alone. These are possible uses, not guarantees of correctness. A model can generate persuasive but mistaken explanations, omit information, and reproduce unjustified criteria.

AI-assisted governance becomes dangerous when a prediction is treated as a verdict and a generated justification is confused with the actual path of a decision. A polished explanation is not an audit. The mandate, relevant data, rules applied, actions actually taken, and point at which human responsibility was exercised must be known.

One design principle is separation of roles: the system that recommends should not automatically hold authority to execute, and the system that executes should not be the sole evaluator of its own action. For decisions with serious effects, there must be a real avenue of challenge, not merely a form that sends the complaint back to the same mechanism.

AI should not turn citizens into objects that are permanently scored. An administration may need to detect fraud; it does not follow that it may calculate a general index of social worth and make access to life conditional on it. When a score becomes an identity, an error may travel between institutions faster than the right to correct it.

Distributing intelligence requires institutions of distribution

A cosmolocal approach would combine accessible tools, shared regional infrastructure, portability standards, and markets that remain open to entry. Not every community needs to train the largest model. Communities need to be able to change providers, verify important functions, and retain enough expertise to avoid dependence on an unavoidable black box.

There is, however, a real conflict between access and safety. Powerful capabilities can also be used to cause harm. Unlimited access to every capability is not a necessary condition of freedom, just as unlimited central control is not a sufficient condition of safety. Restrictions must be tied to specific, contestable, and reviewable risks, not to the permanent privilege of incumbent providers.

The decisive question of the AI age is not only whether machines will surpass us. It is whether the power to use machines to constrain others can be challenged. Abundance can change many economic constraints. It does not abolish the problem of who holds the key.

CHAPTER 15

Basic income: a floor for freedom or a pension for subjects?

An unconditional income can strengthen the power to refuse. It can also stabilize an order in which the majority no longer owns anything decisive.

What money can and cannot solve

A universal basic income, often called UBI, is a periodic transfer granted to individuals without an employment test or work requirement, under the program's eligibility rules. Universality must be defined: citizens, residents, adults, or children receiving differentiated amounts. The term alone specifies neither the transfer level nor its funding or the services that remain available.

Such an income can reduce dependence on an abusive employer or coercive family. It can allow care, education, or the search for more suitable work. These are possible mechanisms. The size of the effects depends on the income level, prices, services, and alternatives. A transfer that is too small may offer too little to make refusal credible.

Money does not automatically create housing, health care, or energy. When the supply of an essential good is rigid and market power is strong, some of the benefit may be absorbed by prices and rents. This is not an inevitable result of every UBI, but it is a reason to assess the transfer alongside the structure of markets and services.

What the experiments show and where their reach ends

Vivalt and colleagues studied a program in which a group of low-income adults received $1,000 a month for three years, while a control group received $50. The results report a moderate reduction in labor-force participation and hours worked, around one to two hours a week, without a general shift of the freed time into detectable productive investment. The study confirms neither the disappearance of work nor the promise that unconditional money automatically turns people into entrepreneurs or students. [37]

Jones and Marinescu, analyzing Alaska's permanent dividend through a different empirical strategy, find no reduction in aggregate employment and do find an increase in part-time work. The transfer differs, however, in size, permanence, and context. It is not an experiment on a fully automated society. [38]

These results are not logically contradictory. A temporary program for part of the population and a widely distributed dividend can have different effects on demand, bargaining, and work. Generalizing to an income sufficient for an entire life and granted to everyone in an AI-transformed economy goes beyond what the studies demonstrate.

Arithmetic cannot be replaced by enthusiasm

A purely hypothetical example: for one million adults, a transfer of 1,000 currency units a month has a gross annual cost of 12 billion. If a tax mechanism recovers seven billion from some recipients in this invented scenario, the net redistributive transfer would be five billion before other budget changes. This is not an estimate for any country; it shows why gross and net costs must not be confused.

Even net cost does not exhaust the issue. The source of revenue, the tax base's response, administrative costs, and which programs are replaced must be explained. A UBI funded by cutting services indispensable to people with high needs can look generous on paper and be regressive in practice. A dividend funded by volatile profits cannot promise stability without reserves and adjustment rules.

AI could expand the resource base. It does not automatically give the state the right and capacity to collect those resources. Ownership, tax competition, and capital mobility will continue to matter. A serious policy must explain the institution that turns productivity into social income, not merely assume that the transformation will happen.

Transfers, ownership, services, and voice

Dependence differs when citizens receive a revocable allowance from a center and when they hold strong legal rights, a stake in capital funds, and productive alternatives. Basic income can be one component of emancipation. It should not become a substitute for all other forms of economic power.

One possible combination would include a guaranteed minimum, essential services, diversified social funds, cooperative ownership, and access to productive capacity. Funds should be protected both from political confiscation and managerial capture. Diversification can, in principle, keep the entire social dividend from becoming a bet on one company or technical apparatus; it does not eliminate financial risk or distributive conflict.

Contribution obligations may exist in precise forms: obeying the law, paying taxes owed, caring responsibilities, and participation in certain justified shared tasks. But access to subsistence must not depend on political approval of one's way of life. A system in which income depends on an obedience score is not emancipatory UBI but the management of behavior through dependence.

Paternalism begins with an unspoken contract

The dangerous contract sounds like this: we govern and own; you receive comfort and entertainment; in exchange, you stop questioning power. It need not be stated explicitly to become practice. A materially protected population can still lack control over its future.

But an unconditional transfer does not necessarily lead to this outcome. Its unconditional nature, legal stability, and plurality of income sources can themselves reduce arbitrariness. The crucial distinction is between an enforceable right and an administered favor. The former supports refusal. The latter buys gratitude.

The verdict is not “UBI good” or “UBI bad.” The right question is what power relationship the entire arrangement produces. An automated society does not become free merely because nobody starves. It becomes freer when nobody has to thank a master for permission to live.

CHAPTER 16

What do we do with people when their work is no longer needed?

Freedom from necessity can open up life. It can also remove the structures through which people find their place, rhythm, and recognition.

The question already contains a danger

“What do we do with people?” is a natural way to frame an administrative problem and, at the same time, the beginning of a paternalistic position. It casts some as organizers of existence and others as a population that needs to be kept busy. A free civilization should not ask an elite to invent purposes for the rest of humanity.

Yet the problem does not disappear if we rephrase it. For many people, work organizes time, relationships, status, and a sense of usefulness. The hypothesis that much necessary work will disappear requires us to examine what structures could fulfill those functions. It is not enough to assume that everyone will suddenly discover a remarkable passion.

Not everyone will want to write poetry, understand cosmology, or explore space. Not everyone will have the ability or energy. An abundance project that accepts only spectacular lives preserves the old hierarchy of performance under another name. It replaces the obligation to produce with the obligation to be interesting.

There must be room for ordinary lives: relationships, caring for someone, modest skill, sport, conversation, ritual, nature, chosen repetitive activities, and local belonging. Failing to produce something original for all humanity does not mean being useless. A life need not become a civilizational project to have value.

Why entertainment is not a constitution

Consensual sex, music, games, and virtual worlds are not inherently inferior forms of existence. Pleasure need not be justified by productivity. Yet an industry capable of providing unlimited stimulation cannot by itself guarantee autonomy, belonging, and respect. The issue is not the volume of available content, but a person's relationship to the life they live.

A virtual world can support genuine relationships and demanding projects. It can also be an environment from which an administrator can exclude you, change your property, and shape your attention without oversight. If physical dependence on wages is replaced by psychological and social dependence on a platform, emancipation remains partial.

Abundance of objects does not imply abundance of every good. Other people's attention, prestige, influence over decisions, and certain positions remain limited. Anderson and colleagues synthesize evidence on the importance of status as a human motive. Status does not exhaust motivation, and neither does material security. Forms of recognition differ between people. [40]

Here lies a difficulty that utopias underestimate. You can give everyone a comfortable room. You cannot give everyone the position of most-admired person in the same community. Positional goods do not multiply like copies of a file.

The desire to dominate does not disappear with hunger

Cheng and colleagues distinguish two paths to social rank: dominance, associated with the ability to impose costs, and prestige, associated with deference to valued skill or contributions. This distinction is not a moral classification of people. It separates being followed because one is appreciated from being followed because one is feared. [41]

An abundant society may reduce some causes of conflict and retain others. Someone may desire control even without material need. They may seek adventure, the submission of others, or the satisfaction of breaking limits. We have no reason to assume these possibilities disappear automatically. Nor do we have proof that they will characterize most people.

Research by Pfattheicher and colleagues finds links between boredom and certain forms of sadistic aggression under the conditions studied. This is a limited warning, not grounds for predicting that billions of people without jobs will become violent. Moving from a contextual psychological effect to the fate of a civilization would require further theory and data. [42]

The institutional issue remains even without that generalization: how do we channel the desire for challenge and influence without making real people the material for others' adventures? Sports competition, games, exploration, and public projects may offer some answers. They must not, however, be treated as mandatory sedatives administered to people presumed dangerous by default.

An ecology of meaning, not a ministry of meaning

The proposal is for a plurality of environments in which a person can matter. Workshops, learning communities, care, associations, competitions, participatory research, and local forms of deliberation can offer roles with different entry thresholds. Not everyone needs to be the best, and success criteria need not be identical everywhere.

Some activities may remain paid even in a highly automated economy because they involve trust, a preference for human contact, or responsibility. Others may be voluntary. People should be able to change the intensity of participation throughout life. There is no reason to turn free time into another universal norm of performance.

At the same time, a community needs reciprocity. Rejecting paternalism does not mean declaring every obligation abusive. What needs justification is the link among an obligation, the common good, and a sanction. A precise, proportionate, and equally applied shared task differs from a permanent assessment of a person's usefulness.

The hardest question remains: will these environments suffice for a large majority over very long periods? We do not know. Experiments with income, leisure, and voluntary communities do not reproduce a world in which human economic contribution has become marginal. The clear-eyed conclusion is that meaning after work should be researched before being administered on a planetary scale.

Nor does the lack of a final answer justify deliberately maintaining poverty. Keeping people under pressure because we do not know what they would do if free is a severe political choice, not mere caution. A mature society must learn to offer freedom without assuming it will produce only lives that please its designers.

CHAPTER 17

The antinomies that remain after wealth is distributed

Even a fairer distribution of resources leaves conflicts between transparency and privacy, efficiency and resilience, and the present and the future.

Transparency that sees too much

Corruption hides. It may therefore seem that the solution is to make everything visible. But a fully transparent society would give the powerful detailed maps of everyone's vulnerabilities. Citizens would lose the space in which to think, experiment, and form relationships without surveillance.

Transparency in the exercise of power must be distinguished from universal exposure of the person. Public decisions, conflicts of interest, and the use of common resources require visibility. Private life requires protection, with limited and justified exceptions. Even a public administrator does not lose all private rights; what should be visible is what is relevant to the role, not an entire existence.

There are difficult cases. Exposing wrongdoing may disclose information about victims. Auditing a system may require access to sensitive data. One possible solution is tiered oversight: independent access to necessary data, publication of conclusions, and avenues to challenge decisions, without indiscriminately publishing all the material. But the auditor then becomes a new point of trust and must also be overseen.

There is no state in which everything is simultaneously perfectly verifiable and perfectly private for every observer. There are choices about who may learn what, for what purpose, and with what responsibility. The architecture of information is political architecture.

Efficiency that removes reserves

An organization can become cheaper by concentrating supply in one place, standardizing, and reducing reserves. Under normal conditions, the result may be excellent. During a shock, the same dependence can become a vulnerability. We need invoke no universal law to see that an eliminated alternative is unavailable when the main provider fails.

Decentralization and redundancy have costs. They can mean duplicate tools, professionals who are not permanently occupied, and capacity kept for rare situations. These costs are not automatically waste. They may buy continuity and bargaining power. But they may also justify unnecessary structures protected by the impossibility of proving what would have happened without them.

The solution is explicit risk assessment and testing of alternatives, not veneration of either efficiency or redundancy. Critical infrastructure must show how it operates when its dominant component is no longer available. A local project must show that its autonomy is not a label concealing hidden dependencies.

Family care and equality of opportunity

Parents want to help their children. A society that banned every family advantage would invade fundamental relationships and require intolerable surveillance. But unrestricted transmission of advantages can turn competition among people into competition among family fortunes.

The antinomy needs no villains. The same behavior can be care at the family level and reproduction of inequality in the aggregate. The conclusion is not that affection should be punished. It is that society must build routes to opportunity independent of family: good education, protection against abuse, health care, and chances to start again after failure.

Even these routes will not produce perfect equality of opportunity. Relationships, time, ways of life, and birthplace will continue to matter. A clear-eyed policy must reduce avoidable disadvantages without promising complete equality that could be pursued only through administrative domination.

The future cannot vote, and the present cannot be confiscated

A civilization seeking to endure for centuries must take account of people who do not yet exist. Budgets, infrastructure, and the environment have consequences beyond an electoral term. Yet invoking the future can justify any sacrifice imposed on people living now by an elite that claims to know their destiny.

Neither an exclusive preference for the present nor unlimited guardianship in the name of the future is acceptable. A more prudent approach protects the conditions of possibility: functioning ecosystems, the capacity to learn, the avoidance of irreversible harm, and the preservation of alternatives for those who come after us. We do not have to design the lives of future generations in detail; we have to avoid leaving them only one option.

This logic is relevant to AI as well. A decision that creates irreversible infrastructural dependence requires a different threshold of justification from a local experiment that can be reversed. Reversibility is not a decorative precaution but a resource of freedom for people who did not take part in the original choice.

Protecting ecosystems and the freedom to consume

Abundance of information does not mean the absence of physical limits. Even with highly advanced technologies, land use, material flows, and effects on other forms of life remain problems of coordination. This claim requires no precise prediction of future technologies: easing one constraint is not logically equivalent to abolishing all constraints.

A cosmolocal society can export ecological costs just as a centralized one can if it measures only its internal benefits. Local control must be supplemented by obligations to those outside it. Community autonomy is not a right to pollute a neighbor's river or exhaust a resource on which others depend.

Over the very long term, sustainability cannot mean freezing culture and demography according to a single design. A stable civilization is not necessarily an unchanging one. More plausibly, it is one capable of changing institutions and technologies without destroying the conditions for life or permanently suspending a person's moral status. Stability must include adaptation, not be confused with obedience.

CHAPTER 18

A constitution for a world that cannot be perfect

We cannot eliminate domination once and for all. We can design institutions in which its accumulation is harder, more visible, and easier to undo.

A proposal, not a necessary deduction

I call “constitutional cosmolocalism” a family of arrangements that combine distributed economic capacities, globally circulating knowledge, shared rights, and coordination at the scale of each problem. The term names this book’s proposal, not an already validated doctrine or the only possible path. Some components can be realized within existing democracies without changing their names.

The central value is not the local as such. It is non-domination combined with the capacity to act. A community too weak to protect its members is not free merely because it has an assembly. A highly efficient center is not legitimate merely because it delivers services. We need both questions: what can the institution do, and what is it not allowed to do?

The proposal does not produce a seamless synthesis of doctrines. It preserves conflicts and costs. It regards itself as better only insofar as it allows them to be recognized and corrected without demanding the sacrifice of those who point them out.

First clause: the person belongs neither to the state nor to the community

Basic rights must limit central power as well as local and private authority. No community gains the right to define its dissenting members as persons of lower rank. The choice to belong must be accompanied by the possibility of changing one's affiliation and protection during the transition.

This clause requires a jurisdiction capable of defending the person against local power. The project, therefore, is not pure anarchy. The common center exists, but its mandate must be explicit and limited. The right to intervene to protect a person must not become a right to make every way of life uniform.

Second clause: concentration is measured along several axes

Measuring the distribution of wealth is not enough. We must also track control of infrastructure, information, political financing, professional advancement, and force. An actor of moderate wealth can be extremely powerful if it controls access to an essential service.

This calls for independent, public assessments of dependencies, not a single score for power. Indicators can be manipulated; therefore, several methods and the possibility of challenging them are needed. The goal is not to eliminate large actors but to prevent the conversion of advantage into authority immune to scrutiny.

Third clause: critical infrastructure must have alternatives

Interoperability, portability, and the ability to substitute providers must be treated as public goods. A service may be supplied commercially, cooperatively, or publicly. But where its withdrawal would paralyze civic life, credible continuity plans and practically tested alternatives must exist.

This requirement has costs and cannot be applied identically to every product. Thresholds must be set according to criticality, substitutability, and effects on rights. A company should not be broken up because it is competent; nor should it be allowed to turn competence into captivity with no exit.

Fourth clause: a minimum income does not buy silence

Basic material protection must be predictable and legally contestable. It cannot depend on opinions, participation in political ceremonies, or a general index of behavior. Any legitimate sanction must be tied to an act and a procedure, not to an overall loss of a person's worth.

The transfer must be accompanied by services and access to forms of productive ownership. Otherwise society can become a comfortably administered clientele. Freedom requires resources to refuse, but also institutions that cannot arbitrarily confiscate that refusal.

Fifth clause: a decision must have an author and a route of appeal

In public administration, on platforms, and in AI systems, we must be able to identify the mandate, the relevant rule, and the responsible party. Organizational complexity cannot be an excuse for power with no address. “The system decided” is not a sufficient justification.

Not every decision must be explained by publishing all the data. But the affected person must receive an intelligible justification and access to a review that is not identical to the mechanism being challenged. The cost of appeal must be affordable; otherwise the right exists only for those who can pay for it.

Sixth clause: exceptional power must expire

Every emergency mandate must be limited in scope and time. Its renewal must involve independent oversight, and its justification must remain open to examination after the crisis ends. A center cannot extend its own power simply because it declares that the danger persists.

Automatic expiration is not magic either. It can be obstructed or circumvented. The clause therefore needs the backing of institutions with resources of their own, protection for those who refuse unlawful orders, and a culture in which operational success does not confer constitutional immunity.

Seventh clause: competence is selected, not crowned

Technical roles require professional criteria, evaluation, and resources. Selection should not be reduced to popularity. But experts do not gain unlimited authority over values and goals, and their results must be open to relevant criticism.

Limited mandates, declared conflicts of interest, and adversarial review can reduce the transformation of expertise into a caste. Rotation must not destroy institutional memory; permanence must not prevent challenge. We need a combination of continuity in competence and change in leadership.

Eighth clause: plurality of lives is an outcome, not a concession

Institutions should not assume that free people will become alike. Different communities may value different rhythms, occupations, and cultures. What unites them should be respect for shared rights and obligations, not a single ideal of a successful life.

Plurality does not, however, permit a community to impose its rules on outsiders or on members who no longer consent. It is precisely the protection of disagreement that distinguishes a living culture from enforced discipline. The right to belong and the right to cease belonging must be considered together.

Ninth clause: ecological limits and external effects are negotiated at their own scale

A community cannot claim autonomy over consequences that extend beyond its territory. Shared resources and cross-border risks require common rules and institutions. These must make costs visible and represent those affected, including when they are not the most powerful participants.

There is no optimal administrative scale for every problem. Governance must be able to take different forms: local for some services, regional for infrastructure, and broader for global risks. Polycentrism means coordination among centers, not the absence of shared responsibility.

Tenth clause: no architecture is final

A design must specify how it can be changed, abandoned, or replaced without taking possession of participants' lives. Institutional experiments must limit risks and be accompanied by credible comparisons. Success cannot be defined solely by the indicators chosen by the promoter.

This clause is the most important and the most uncomfortable. The proposal must allow its own failure to be recognized. If every criticism is reinterpreted as sabotage, constitutional cosmolocalism has become another ideology that demands victims.

Why this constitution is not enough

An immediate objection is that I have described liberal democracy in its idealized form, adding distributed infrastructure and plural ownership. The objection is partly correct. The project need not reinvent rights and the separation of powers to merit attention. Its proposed novelty is to shift analysis toward economic, digital, and local dependencies that can render those rights ineffective.

Another objection is more severe: all oversight institutions can be captured together. Yes. If the same networks control recruitment, financing, and information, formal plurality can conceal a single center. Independence must therefore be material as well as declared. Different institutions must be able to obtain resources, expertise, and legitimacy from sufficiently distinct sources.

A third objection concerns costs. The architecture may be slow, redundant, and hard to explain. An authoritarian actor may appear more efficient. The answer is not to deny the cost. It is to compare ordinary efficiency with the potential cost of power that can no longer be corrected. Some administrative savings are gained by selling the ability to say no.

We do not have a constitution that eliminates walking on eggshells. We have the outline of an order in which we do not all have to step on the same shell, and in which the cracking of one institution does not require the destruction of the whole world.

CHAPTER 19

The adversary's test and the road to get there

An institution is not vindicated by the beauty of its rules. We must see what happens when someone tries to exploit them.

Five ways to break the project

The first attack is a cartel of administrators. Several institutions formally exist, but their leaders come from the same network, finance one another's projects, and share information selectively. The separation of powers becomes choreography. The response must include diversity in recruitment, sufficiently independent financing, and the possibility of investigation from outside the circle. Collusion remains a residual risk: no organizational chart makes it impossible.

The second attack is a community that persecutes its minority. The local majority believes its autonomy permits it to control members' religion, expression, or departure. Here the project must choose: if it protects collective autonomy against the individual, it turns into authoritarian localism. If it intervenes from above without limits, it risks central uniformity. The test is whether an outside arbiter can protect specific rights without permanently taking over the governance of every aspect of local life.

The third attack is an emergency without end. A real danger gives the center additional powers; after the danger subsides, the center finds reasons to retain them. Legal expiration helps only if actors capable of enforcing it exist. The test must track not only the declaration of emergency but also the restoration of ordinary powers, access to records, and the consequences of exceeding the mandate.

The fourth attack is the indispensable technology provider. A federation uses the same AI models, the same identity infrastructure, and the same payment system. Contracts declare portability, but migration has never been tested. The provider can change the rules knowing that interruption is intolerable. The real test is a controlled migration, with data, skills, and continuity, not the existence of a clause no one can use.

The fifth attack is a public that prefers punishing its opponent to protecting its own future freedom. No technical solution can completely eliminate this possibility. Institutions that delay irreversible changes, protect the opposition, and make consequences visible may help. But

a project claiming to guarantee freedom against every collective choice must explain who receives the authority to annul that choice. The antinomy reappears at the very heart of the solution.

These tests do not prove that the project will fail. They define what it must meet to be taken seriously. An order that publishes its vulnerabilities can be improved. One that declares vulnerabilities impossible invites opportunists to discover them first.

We do not begin by abolishing everything

A total, simultaneous, irreversible transformation would repeat the very error criticized in this book: confidence that the designer knows enough about reality to eliminate every alternative. A better path gradually expands capacities that can be evaluated and can survive changes of government.

One kind of experiment would be shared infrastructure among several administrations or organizations: interoperable tools, transparent procurement, services that can move between providers, and a common verification mechanism. Participants need not share a utopia. A shared interest in reducing a specific dependency is enough.

A second kind would be a fund for local capacity: financing access to tools, repair, learning, and production, with plural administration and public criteria. It must be compared with alternatives, including straightforward commercial procurement. A local workshop that makes expensive, poor products does not become progress simply because it uses the word “community.”

A third kind would be an experiment combining material protection with voluntary opportunities for participation, without an obligation to prove one’s usefulness continually. Research should track not only employment but also autonomy, relationships, financial health, access to services, and costs borne by those outside the program. Neither success nor failure in such a pilot would by itself decide the future of nationwide UBI.

Who accepts a reform that limits their power?

This is the political objection that institutional design often avoids. Those who benefit from concentration will not automatically surrender advantages because an argument is elegant. A reform must also find favorable interests: firms seeking entry to a blocked market, professionals seeking autonomy, administrations seeking independence from vendors, citizens wanting better services, and economic actors who prefer predictable rules to arbitrariness.

The coalition will not be pure. A participant may support interoperability as a rival and reject it once dominant. That is why principles must be tied to rules that also apply to successors, not to promises made in the moment. A good reform must survive its own promoters becoming beneficiaries of the status quo.

The transition also entails legitimate or debatable losses that must be acknowledged. Some investments will be worth less, some roles will disappear, and some communities will need support. Treating every objection as bad faith is the fast route to reformist authoritarianism. Letting every established interest block change is the route to stagnation. Negotiation, justified compensation, and limits on vetoes must be considered together.

What would count as failure?

For a cosmolocal pilot, the number of participants or public visibility is not enough. We should see whether alternatives actually work, dependence on one actor declines, service quality holds up, and vulnerable people can challenge decisions. The cost per beneficiary must be compared with relevant alternatives, not with an imaginary situation that fails completely.

Signs of failure must be established in advance. If a small network monopolizes leadership, if exit becomes very costly, if arbitration systematically favors the same actors, or if shared infrastructure cannot work without one provider, the project must be revised. It is not enough to say implementation betrayed the theory when the theory ignored the foreseeable conditions of implementation.

Research would benefit from comparisons among institutions, longitudinal follow-up, and, where ethical and feasible, random assignment of bounded interventions. Effects on nonparticipants must be included. A project may look excellent for its members precisely because it exports costs to neighbors.

The proposed path is less spectacular than founding a new world. It has, however, a moral and epistemic advantage: it does not require an entire population to become the subject of an experiment without a right to withdraw. The decisive revolution may be to institutionalize modesty, with enough resources and resolve that modesty does not mean impotence.

Epilogue — The light is not a savior

Is there a light at the end of the tunnel? Yes, but not in the form political doctrines usually promise. This book offers no proof that a particular order will remain benign for a thousand years. It offers reasons to believe that some institutions can reduce domination, widen the possibility of refusal, and make mistakes less final.

This is more than consolation and less than salvation. The difference matters. A hope that requires denying human nature and established interests is fragile. A realism that declares every change futile in advance is itself a form of belief without evidence.

The comparison between classical communism and liberal capitalism does not force us to choose between nostalgia and apologetics. The former shows how readily declared equality can conceal a monopoly of power. The latter shows how readily formal freedom can coexist with deeply unequal access and with the conversion of success into influence over the rules. But the difference between being able and unable to challenge power remains decisive. It must not be sacrificed for the pleasure of intellectual symmetry.

Nor should freedom be defended by denying its own conditions. A manipulable population, captured institutions, and weakly developed civic capacities are real dangers to investigate. It does not follow that the answer is a biological aristocracy, a sovereign property-owning class, or an unlimited pedagogical apparatus. These answers concentrate exactly the risk they denounce in others: the power of some people to decide definitively the worth and fate of others.

AI can amplify both directions. It can lower the threshold of access to knowledge and production. It can turn ownership of infrastructure into power almost impossible to refuse. It can reduce unwanted work and leave a void of status. It can support scrutiny of power and

provide power with new tools of surveillance. Neither technological optimism nor fatalism is an inevitable conclusion from technical capability.

Not everyone must become exceptional for a better society to be possible. Ordinary lives must not depend on obedience, and exceptional people must not gain the right to use others without limits. A decent civilization is not one in which everyone produces immortal works. It is one in which no one must be reduced to material for somebody else's project.

The constitutional cosmolocalism proposed here is a conditional direction: distributing capacities without abandoning shared rights; autonomy without local impunity; material protection without buying silence; defensive coordination without an unlimited mandate; experiment without confiscating exit. Every component can fail. That is why the possibility of correction is not the project's final clause. It is the principle that justifies them all.

Will we always walk on eggshells? In one sense, yes: limited beings, with differing interests and unequal power, cannot turn politics into permanent certainty. But we are not condemned to repeat the same fragility. We can distribute risk, build reserves, protect dissent, and learn not to confuse safety with submission.

The light at the end of the tunnel is not the leader who promises to have understood everything. It is the institution in which we can say that the leader has not understood, without our lives being destroyed. It is ownership we can hold without becoming masters of others. It is protection that does not demand political gratitude. It is power large enough to stop abuse and limited enough to be stopped itself.

We do not need a world without conflict in order to hope. We need a world in which conflict does not decide who still has the right to be a person.

Appendix A — What the book claims and how certain it is

Bounded empirical conclusions

Concentrated power can coexist with the official equalization of incomes. Analyses of classical socialist regimes support investigating this mechanism, without proving that every form of egalitarianism produces the same order. [2, 3]

Equal votes do not guarantee equal political influence. The American research discussed is relevant to this risk, but it does not support the claim that the public never influences policy. [11]

Selection algorithms can change exposure and, in some interventions, certain opinions. Effects on use, attitudes, and polarization must not be conflated and are not uniform across platforms. [16, 17]

Unconditional transfers have effects that depend on context. The programs examined demonstrate neither a general collapse of work nor a spontaneous transition to universal creativity. [37, 38]

Knowledge and cognitive outcomes have multiple determinants. The genetic and environmental evidence discussed does not authorize classifying religions or social classes into intellectual castes or predicting civic collapse. [23–26]

The book's own theoretical hypotheses

Advantage may migrate among money, office, infrastructure, information, and force when a reform limits only one dimension. The hypothesis calls for longitudinal observations and cases that could disprove it.

One dominant ladder of status may make social competition more destructive than several arenas of recognition. This is a plausible institutional extension, not the direct result of a single psychological experiment.

Distributing AI infrastructure can strengthen autonomy only if there are skills, alternatives, and rights of contestation. The number of models or nodes is not, by itself, a measure of freedom.

Conclusions this text does not authorize

It does not follow that all regimes are equivalent, that poverty signals biological inferiority, that democracy is doomed by birth rates, or that wealthy owners form a single coordinated organization. Nor does it follow that material abundance automatically creates peace, that UBI automatically creates obedience, or that decentralization eliminates the need for legitimate force.

Nor does it follow that the final institutional proposal has been demonstrated empirically at the scale of a civilization. It is a set of principles and hypotheses that must be compared with alternatives and exposed to revision.

Annex B — A minimal model of the conversion of privilege

What is being measured

For every relevant actor or coalition, research should describe separately economic control, sanctioning capacity, control of access to infrastructure, influence over the agenda, and the ability to escape accountability. These dimensions should not automatically be added into a single score. Some are hard to compare, and the weights would conceal normative judgments.

Conversion relationships matter more than isolated rankings. We can investigate whether wealth increases access to decisions, whether office facilitates the accumulation of wealth, whether infrastructure enables economic sanctions, and whether prestige reduces the likelihood of investigation. Causal direction cannot be inferred from correlations alone.

A conditional proposition

Suppose an organization controls indispensable access, can decide at its discretion who receives it, and those affected have neither a viable alternative nor an independent remedy. Under these conditions, the organization has a capacity to dominate that access, even if its members' formal incomes are not high.

The conclusion follows from the explicitly stated conditions and the sense of non-domination used in the book. It does not demonstrate that these conditions exist everywhere. It does not show that every decision will be abusive. It shows only why an administrator's good-will is not equivalent to an absence of arbitrary dependence.

What could disprove the empirical extension

The general hypothesis that privilege migrates would be weakened by reforms that durably reduce one concentration without relevant increases in other dimensions and without sacrificing the institution's functioning. It would also be weakened if supposed conversions failed to survive control for common causes or if advantaged actors could not, in practice, exploit the opportunities assumed.

A credible test requires advance specification of indicators, the period, and the units of comparison. It must also track the case in which power changes hands without becoming less concentrated. Replacing one elite with another is not necessarily democratization, just as the continued presence of some professionals is not necessarily capture.

Why we do not offer an index of the 'perfect society'

A single score would reward optimizing the indicator and conceal losses among dimensions. A plural dashboard is more suitable: quality of services, independence of remedies, cost of exit, distribution of access, concentration of delivery, and recovery after crises. Some outcomes may be incompatible; choices must be justified publicly, not hidden in a formula.

The minimal model has a modest purpose: to turn a philosophical intuition into questions that may receive uncomfortable answers. If it cannot produce such an answer, it remains political literature, however much mathematics is added.

Annex C — Questions for the next research program

A comparison of egalitarian institutions should track not only income, but the distribution of sanctioning power and access. What arrangements prevent a closed administrative class from emerging? What roles do plural ownership, justice, and occupational mobility play?

Research on resentment should distinguish material deprivation, the gap between expectations and outcomes, loss of status, and mobilization by political actors. The 'elite overproduction' hypothesis must be compared with alternative explanations, not used as a label for every instability.

A program about civic capacities should measure knowledge, self-control, tolerance of disagreement, and justified trust separately. Compressing them into an indicator of human worth would be illegitimate. Educational interventions must be evaluated by outcomes and by respect for participants' freedoms.

Cosmolocal experiments should report full costs, the distribution of participation, and the feasibility of exit. A community that works only for highly motivated participants can be valuable, but it does not demonstrate that it would work for an entire population. Participant selection is part of the explanation, not an inconvenience to hide.

Post-work research must separate comfort, meaning, recognition, and freedom. More free time may have different effects depending on relationships, health, age, and opportunities. Neither a favorable nor an unfavorable response should be mechanically generalized to centuries of abundance.

In every case, the final criterion remains the same: is an increase in well-being accompanied by greater power to contest, or by more comfortable dependence? This book supports the first direction without assuming that comfort lacks value. The distinction is between living well and being able to help define the conditions in which one lives.

Bibliography and notes on sources

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